

Documentation Examples: Subjective vs. Objective Language

Use these examples to guide professional documentation practices.

Objective documentation describes what you observe — what the child does and says, when, where, how often, and for how long. It does not include labels, diagnoses, interpretations, or judgments.

Example 1: Social-Emotional Development

✗ Instead of writing:	✓ Write instead:
<i>Mia is very emotional and dramatic. She can't handle it when she doesn't get her way.</i>	During free play on three separate mornings this week, Mia cried for 8–12 minutes when another child took a toy she was using. She said 'That's mine!' and lay on the floor. She did not respond to verbal redirection during the first 5 minutes of each episode.
Why this is better: The objective version describes specific, observable actions including time, frequency, and exact words. It does not label the child or interpret the behavior. Anyone reading this record can understand exactly what occurred.	

Example 2: Physical or Mobility

✗ Instead of writing:	✓ Write instead:
<i>He has motor problems and can't do anything the other kids do.</i>	During outdoor time, Devon was unable to climb the ladder to the slide independently. He reached the third rung and stopped on 4 out of 5 attempts. He completed the slide with adult hand support. He did not participate in the running game.
Why this is better: The objective version describes specific, observable actions including time, frequency, and exact words. It does not label the child or interpret the behavior. Anyone reading this record can understand exactly what occurred.	

Example 3: Attention and Learning

✗ Instead of writing:	✓ Write instead:
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<i>She is so hyper and can never focus.</i>	During the 20-minute morning circle, Priya left her spot 6 times. She returned when a teacher stood beside her. During small group activities with manipulatives, she remained seated and engaged for 12 minutes continuously.
Why this is better: The objective version describes specific, observable actions including time, frequency, and exact words. It does not label the child or interpret the behavior. Anyone reading this record can understand exactly what occurred.	

Example 4: Sensory Processing

✗ Instead of writing:	✓ Write instead:
<i>He freaks out during lunch because of his sensory issues.</i>	On 8 of the past 10 school days during lunch, Carlos pushed away foods with soft or mushy textures after one or two bites. He said 'yucky' or 'no' and covered his mouth. He ate crackers, carrots, and apple slices without difficulty.
Why this is better: The objective version describes specific, observable actions including time, frequency, and exact words. It does not label the child or interpret the behavior. Anyone reading this record can understand exactly what occurred.	

Example 5: Communication

✗ Instead of writing:	✓ Write instead:
<i>She barely talks. She's really delayed.</i>	During a 30-minute observation of free play, Nadia communicated primarily using gestures (pointing, reaching) and 3–4 single words. She did not yet use two-word combinations during this observation. She responded to her name 3 out of 5 times.
Why this is better: The objective version describes specific, observable actions including time, frequency, and exact words. It does not label the child or interpret the behavior. Anyone reading this record can understand exactly what occurred.	

Example 6: Challenging Behavior During Transitions

✗ Instead of writing:	✓ Write instead:
<i>He's defiant every time we clean up. He's manipulative.</i>	During clean-up time on Monday, Tuesday, and Wednesday, Eli sat under the table and said 'I don't want to' when given the clean-up

	direction. He remained under the table for 5–7 minutes on each day. He joined the group after a teacher sat beside him and offered a specific task.
Why this is better: The objective version describes specific, observable actions including time, frequency, and exact words. It does not label the child or interpret the behavior. Anyone reading this record can understand exactly what occurred.	

Example 7: Peer Interaction

✗ Instead of writing:	✓ Write instead:
<i>She has no friends and doesn't know how to play with other kids.</i>	Over the past three weeks, Sofia played independently or beside peers on 14 out of 15 observed days. On 1 day, she entered a peer's play and stayed for 4 minutes before leaving. She has not yet initiated conversation with peers during observation periods.
Why this is better: The objective version describes specific, observable actions including time, frequency, and exact words. It does not label the child or interpret the behavior. Anyone reading this record can understand exactly what occurred.	